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Visitors came and went from Xu Qingzhu's hospital room.

In comparison, Liang Shi's side was very empty. Apart from Zhao Xuning, her attending physician, who kept watch over her, no one else had come to visit.

Oh, Su Yao and Sheng Linlang had visited Liang Shi a few times out of "loving the house and its crow"¹.

After visiting, they even asked Zhao Xuning, "Is her condition serious?"

Upon learning that her injuries were sustained because of Xu Qingzhu, both mothers showed expressions of sympathy.

Su Yao also asked Sheng Linlang, "Jie, what foods help generate blood?"

Sheng Linlang didn't know either and tentatively asked back: "Pig blood? You are what you eat."²

Standing to the side, Zhao Xuning's mouth twitched at what she heard. Afraid they would do something useless, she had to remind them: "After the patient wakes up, I'll give you a list of foods for dietary supplementation, along with eating schedules. Right now nothing can be used—we don't even know when she'll wake up."

Only then did Su Yao and Sheng Linlang give up.

However, unlike Sheng Linlang, Su Yao knew nothing about the Liang family. Having stayed abroad for so long, she was no longer familiar with these families in their social circle. Even after seeing Zhao Xuning, she thought for a long time before tentatively asking, "Are you Wang Ye's daughter?"

Wang Ye was Zhao Xuning's mother.

Zhao Xuning nodded in confirmation.

Only then did Su Yao say: "Your mother and I had a pretty good relationship before. We were in consecutive grades in high school."

Zhao Xuning responded politely with a few words. Afterward, Su Yao quietly asked her: "What about Liang Shi's family? Why haven't I seen them? Does she have no other relatives?"

Zhao Xuning paused, momentarily unsure how to explain it to her, so she could only tell a well-intentioned lie: "Liang Shi's family doesn't know she's injured yet. Because her injuries weren't considered particularly serious that day, no critical condition notice was issued. Besides, I'm here—she won't have any major problems."

After saying this, she added: "She has relatives, they're just quite busy. She also doesn't really want to trouble her relatives, so I didn't notify them."

Su Yao responded with a dazed "okay."

On the other hand, Sheng Yu would come after school, staying in the hospital room until evening.

When Su Yao saw she was tired and wanted to take her away, she said while yawning: "I'm not tired. I want to keep jiejie company."

In the end, she stubbornly fell asleep lying on the edge of Xu Qingzhu's hospital bed.

After Xu Qingzhu woke up, people came and went from the hospital room again—one group would come and another would leave. There was always someone in the room, but Xu Qingzhu didn't talk to anyone.

She was only slightly different with Su Yao.

As if she still remembered that Su Yao's mental condition wasn't very good, she would reluctantly say to Su Yao: "You should go back."

Her tone was careful and cautious, as if afraid of hurting her.

When Su Yao stared at her with tear-filled eyes and tears fell down, Xu Qingzhu just sat there frowning, looking somewhat impatient.

This relapse was much more severe than before. Dr. Gu readjusted the medication for Xu Qingzhu to take, along with some scientific treatment methods.

Zhao Xuning came to find Gu Junru because she wanted to take Xu Qingzhu to see Liang Shi.

It was Zhao Xuning who proposed this method, because Gu Junru had said that Xu Qingzhu rarely spoke, and once she did, the two words she said most were—jiejie.

And they all knew that the word "jiejie" referred to Liang Shi.

In that kidnapping case, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu had depended on each other for survival.

Afterward, Liang Shi's temperament changed drastically, while Xu Qingzhu was left with PTSD³.

What they experienced during that time, only they themselves knew.

And the grown-up Xu Qingzhu had voluntarily married Liang Shi. Even knowing that her reputation was bad, she had still plunged in without hesitation.

It was just unexpected that things remained the same but people had changed⁴.

The only method Zhao Xuning could think of to stimulate Xu Qingzhu was to take her to see Liang Shi.

But this method carried risks, so Dr. Gu had to come along.

When Zhao Xuning and Gu Junru arrived at the hospital room, Xu Qingzhu was lying on the bed with her eyes open, staring at the ceiling. Her eyes were lifeless, her hands resting on her abdomen—no one knew what she was thinking.

Zhao Xuning stepped forward and spoke coldly, "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu didn't move.

Zhao Xuning paused and said: "Do you want to go see Liang Shi?"

Only upon hearing the name "Liang Shi" did Xu Qingzhu have a slight reaction. Her neck turned to look at Zhao Xuning. Those clear eyes appeared lifeless and dazed, without any of their usual spirit.

Seeing it was effective, Zhao Xuning continued: "Your wife, the jiejie who was kidnapped together with you when you were little, the jiejie you've always been thinking about—Liang Shi."

The hospital room was completely silent. Both Gu Junru and Zhao Xuning were nervous, unsure whether this method would work on Xu Qingzhu.

Back then, Gu Junru had used traditional therapy to help Xu Qingzhu, trying countless methods. It took nearly two months just to get Xu Qingzhu to speak to her.

Building a bridge of communication between the two of them had taken nearly a year.

But at this moment, after a long silence, a glimmer of light flickered in Xu Qingzhu's eyes, and she lightly pressed her lips together.

She had small physical movements, which meant she was thinking.

A few seconds later, Xu Qingzhu sat up, her hands propping herself up on the hospital bed. A hint of color appeared on that face so pale it was nearly transparent, and her cool, clear voice rang out in the hospital room.

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Where is she?"

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu said: "I want to see her."

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1. "Loving the house and its crow" (愛屋及烏) - A Chinese idiom meaning to love someone so much that you extend that love to everything associated with them. In this case, because they love Xu Qingzhu, they also care about Liang Shi who is important to her. ↵
 2. "You are what you eat" (吃什麼補什麼) - A traditional Chinese belief that eating certain animal parts will nourish the corresponding parts of your own body. Here, the suggestion is that eating pig blood would help replenish blood. ↵
 3. PTSD - Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder, referred to in the original as 創傷應激障礙. ↵
 4. "Things remained the same but people had changed" (物是人非) - A Chinese idiom expressing that while external circumstances may appear unchanged, the people involved have fundamentally changed. Here it refers to how although Xu Qingzhu married the same person she knew from childhood, Liang Shi was no longer the original person (the current Liang Shi is the transmigrated soul). ↵